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Source: *Novum Testamentum*, Apr., 1983, Vol. 25, Fasc. 2 (Apr., 1983), pp. 152-181

Published by: Brill

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THE STRUCTURE OF I CORINTHIANS AND PAUL'S THEOLOGICAL METHOD WITH SPECIAL REFERENCE TO 4:17

by

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Problems relating to the composition of I Corinthians have been widely discussed for decades. Conzelmann writes of the "loose construction" and of the "breaks and joins."¹ Héring, Schmithals and Weiss feel that these "breaks and joins" demonstrate that various letters compiled at various times have been brought together by an editor.² Barrett, Conzelmann and Orr/Walther cautiously affirm unity for the entire book as it now stands.³ Orr/Walther mention the traditional outline, which is:

- A. Subjects raised with Paul orally by messengers from Corinth, 1-6.
- B. Subjects about which the Corinthians have written, 7-16.

Orr/Walther then observe a series of alleged inserts into the major topics of the letter and note:

One has to decide whether these inserts are to be connected with the topics from the letters Paul is answering or are to be interpreted as independent items—and this in turn bears upon the editorial unity of the epistle.⁴

Barrett discusses the same problem, follows the same two-fold division suggested above, and writes:

I Corinthians is a long letter. When it was written Paul was energetically engaged in vigorous evangelistic and pastoral activity, and may at the same time have been earning his living by working at a trade. How much leisure he had for writing

¹ Hans Conzelmann, *I Corinthians* (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1975), p. 2.

² Jean Héring, *The First Epistle of Saint Paul to the Corinthians* (London: Epworth Press, 1962), p. xiii-vx; W. Schmithals, *Paul and the Gnostics* (New York: Abingdon, 1972), p. 245-253; J. Weiss, *The History of Primitive Christianity* (New York: K. W. Wilson-Erickson, 1937), p. i, 356f.

³ C. K. Barrett, *A Commentary on the First Epistle to the Corinthians* (New York: Harper and Row, 1968), p. 14-17; Conzelmann, *op. cit.*, p. 2-3; William F. Orr and James A. Walther, *I Corinthians* in *The Anchor Bible* (New York: Doubleday, 1976), Vol. 32, 120-122.

⁴ Orr/Walther, *op. cit.*, 122.

we do not know; probably not much. This means that the writing of the letter will have been spread over some time; it may well have been laid aside from time to time, and taken up again after an interval. A letter written in such circumstances may be expected to show occasional inconsistencies and passages in which the same topic is looked at from different points of view. Fresh news may reach the writer; plans may change with changing needs and opportunities.⁵

Coupled with the above rationale for the supposed disjointedness of I Corinthians is the often made affirmation that the book is a *practical letter*, not a theological treatise. Thus naturally, no careful, ordered presentation of material is expected, we are told. Again Barrett writes,

I Corinthians is anything but a work of systematic theology. It is a practical letter addressed to a single, though complex situation, aimed at telling its readers not so much what they ought to think as what they ought to do—or ought not to do.

At the same time Barrett also observes, “The practical advice, however, is consciously grounded in theological principles which can usually be detected.”⁶ Yet, in spite of this later admission, the conclusion that Barrett and many others come to is that the book is, as it were, “written on the run,” and that its outline is dictated by the list of questions that have come first orally (1-6) and then in writing (7-16) from Corinth. It is practical, not theological we are told, occasional, not universal in outlook.

To this widely held position we would offer an alternative. The view here presented is that the entire book has a carefully designed inner coherence that exhibits amazing precision in detail of composition and admirable grandeur in overall theological concept. In this brief article we will argue that the outline of I Corinthians is as precise as the Letter to the Romans; and that it falls into five carefully constructed essays that themselves exhibit a discernible theological method both internally as individual essays and together as a collection.⁷ I Cor. 4:17 will be seen as an indirect statement of

⁵ Barrett, *op. cit.*, 15.

⁶ *Ibid.*, 17.

⁷ Towards the end of the nineteenth century G. G. Findlay, in *The Expositor's Greek Testament*, proposed a six-fold division of I Corinthians. With the exception of including 4:17-21 in his first section, his first five divisions are identical to our proposal for five essays. The internal structure of each essay, the relationships between essays, and the theological method the essays exhibit Findlay did not observe. Yet it is important to note that prior to the twentieth century debate, briefly reviewed above, most of our suggested overall outline was observed. Cf. G. G. Findlay, *St. Paul's First Epistle to the Corinthians* in *The Expositor's Greek Testament*, Ed. by W. R. Nicholl (New York: George Doran Company, n.d.), Vol. II, 754. In

the theological method as well as an introduction to the second essay. To help clarify our subject we would summarize our findings and then proceed with a defense of our thesis.

The overall outline of the five essays (reduced to their simplest form) is as follows:

- I. The Cross 1:5-4:16
- II. Men and Women in the Human Family (sex) 4:17-7:40
- III. Food Offered to Idols (Christian and pagan) 8:1-11:1
- IV. Men and Women in Worship (love) 11:2-14:40
- V. The Resurrection 15

When the complementary pairs of essays are placed together it can be seen that Paul has three principle ideas on his mind. These are:

1. The cross and the resurrection (I,V)
2. Men and women (in the human family and in worship; sex and love, II,IV)
3. Christians and pagans (to identify or not to identify, III)

Some of the Corinthians' questions (oral and written) are worked into Paul's outline, rather than the other way around. *He* sets the agenda, not the Corinthians. The material is theological as well as ethical and there is a heavy emphasis on the tradition of the whole church.

We propose a new look at some aspects of I Corinthians, as well as a new look at its author's methodology. The secondary literature that relates to this problem is enormous. It is not our intent to review and debate all that has been said. Rather, with a full awareness of the new direction we are here proposing, we proceed to a brief summary of our findings.

Each of Paul's five essays follows the same form. The form has five sections. These are as follows:

1. The Tradition. (This is referred to, but not quoted, three times and on three occasions directly quoted. The idea of *reminding* and *remembering* in connection with the tradition is mentioned in three out of the five essays.)
2. A Practical/Ethical Problem is presented (in its more negative aspects).

1889 F. L. Godet combined chapters 5-10 under the title, "Five Moral Questions," but otherwise his outline is identical to that of Findlay. Cf. F. L. Godet, *Commentary on First Corinthians* (Grand Rapids: Kregel Publications, c. English Tr. 1889, 1979), p. 27-31.

3. A very carefully written General Theological Statement is set forth that lays a foundation out of which the problem must be addressed. This foundation is (in each of the five essays) presented as two aspects of a single theme
4. The Practical/Ethical Problem is readdressed (in its more positive aspects).
5. A Concluding Appeal is made. There are five such appeals (one after each section). Two of these have the "imitate me" theme; two reflect "I have the spirit/command of the Lord," and two have the imperative "therefore, my beloved brethren, etc." (The appeal after the fourth essay is double.)

The outline of the book (with the central theological sections italicised) is given in Plate A below.

Each of Paul's five essays will need to be examined in turn. The first essay discusses the cross, leadership and unity, and is structured as follows:

1. The Tradition: (referred to in connection with an introduction to all five essays). "The testimony to Christ" (1:6)
2. Paul, Apollos and Cephas: (Paul here presents the problem. The Corinthians see these leaders only as heads of competing factions. 1:10-16).
3. We preach: Christ crucified - not human wisdom (1:17-2:5)
We preach: a hidden wisdom of God (2:6-16)
2. Paul, Apollos and Cephas: (Paul tells the Corinthians precisely how they are to look at apostolic leadership. They are servants of Christ and stewards of the mysteries of God. At the same time they do have a leadership role to play. 3, 4).
1. The Concluding Appeal: "I urge you - imitate me!" (4:16)

We have noted above that each of the five essays opens with *some* reference to the tradition. However, there is considerable freedom exercised in style of presentation of the tradition. We observe the following; in three out of the five cases (II, IV, V) the presentation of the tradition is prefaced with reference to remembering. In each of these three the reference to the tradition immediately follows this call. In the other two essays (I, III) the reference to the tradition is incorporated into a more general statement. Three times the tradition/creed is quoted. (We will return to this topic in our discussion of the fourth essay.)

PLATE A

The Outline of I Cor.

Greetings and prayer of thanksgiving 1:1-9

I. *The Cross, leadership and unity* 1:4-4:16

THE TRADITION: "The testimony to Christ was confirmed among you."

A Paul, Apollos and Cephas 1:10-16 (-)

B *We preach: no worldly wisdom—only the Cross* 1:17-2:5

B' *We preach: a hidden wisdom of God* 2:6-16

A' Paul, Apollos and Cephas 3,4 (+)

CONCLUDING APPEAL: "I urge you—be imitators of me."

II. *Sex* (men and women in the human family) 4:17-7:40

THE TRADITION: "—to remind you of my ways in Christ—
as I teach them everywhere in every Church"

A Incest and Church judgment 5-6:11 (-)

B *Theology of Human Sexuality* (food and sex not equal) 6:11-14

B' *Theology of Human Sexuality* (united with the Lord) 6:14-20

A' Christian patterns of sexuality 7 (+)

CONCLUDING APPEAL: "I think that I have the spirit of God."

III. *Idols* (Christian and non-Christian) 8-11:1

THE TRADITION/CREED:

"For us there is one God, the Father
from whom are all things and for whom we exist,
and one Lord, Jesus Christ,
through whom are all things and through whom we exist."

A Food offered to idols 8 (-)

B *Theology of Mission* "free from/slave to all men" 9
(identification)

B' *Theology of Mission* "Sacrament and Ethics" 10:1-22
(non-identification)

A' Food offered to idols 10:23-11:1 (+)

CONCLUDING APPEAL: "Be imitators of me as I am of Christ."

IV. *Worship, gifts and love* (men and women in worship) 11:2-14

THE TRADITION:

"You remember me in everything
and maintain the traditions as I delivered them to you."
+ "I received from the Lord what I also delivered to you—"

A Worship (men and women) 11 (-)

B Spiritual gifts 12 (-)

C *Love* 13 (defined negatively and positively)

B' Spiritual gifts. 14:1-25 (+)

A' Worship (men and women) 14:26-40 (+)

CONCLUDING APPEAL: "What I am writing to you is a command of the Lord.
So, my brethern, earnestly desire to—"

V. *The Resurrection* 15

THE TRADITION/CREED:

"I would remind you in what word I preached the gospel"
+ the CREED

A *If Christ is not raised* v. 12-20 (-)

B *Adam and Christ*—God's final plan v. 21-28

C Personal witness v. 29-34

B' *Adam and Christ*—the spiritual body v. 35-50

A' *The Great Mystery - victory!* v. 51-57 (+)

CONCLUDING APPEAL:

"Therefore, my beloved brethern, be steadfast,
immovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord,"

Personal notes—16

In this first essay the reference to the tradition appears as a part of an introduction that serves a number of purposes (4-9). It begins as a prayer of thanksgiving for the faith of the Corinthians (1:4-5). It then quickly moves beyond this to both a general introduction to all five essays as well as a specific introduction to the first essay. The themes of each of the five essays are directly or indirectly referred to in these verses as follows:

1:4-9

You were *enriched* in him with
all speech and all knowledge
 Christ - who will sustain you
to the end guiltless
 The *fellowship/participation*
 of his Son
 Not lacking in any
spiritual gift
 You wait for *the revealing of*
our Lord

The five essays

- I. Cross and *Wisdom* (no wise words)
- II. Sex (reject the evil person in order to save him in the day of the Lord Jesus)
- III. Idols (and fellowship/participation)
- IV. Worship (the spiritual gifts and love)
- V. Resurrection (and the future hope)

Thus in one brief paragraph Paul makes some mention of what is coming in each of the five essays to follow. At the same time there is a clear reference to the tradition in the phrase, "the testimony of Christ," that was confirmed among them. This testimony is not quoted (cf. 4:17 and 11:2). The tradition that Paul has in mind is most likely that which he quotes in 15:3-7. There in the fifth essay the subject is only the *resurrection* and yet the creed quoted deals with both the resurrection *and the cross*. Furthermore, here in 1:6 Paul talks of the testimony to Christ being *confirmed* among them. Then in 15:1-2 we read of the gospel "which you received, in which you stand, by which you are saved." (Other parallels between the first essay and the last will be observed in our discussion of Chapter 15 below.) Here we would merely note that there *is* a reference to a "testimony to Christ" and suggest that in light of the fact that the first essay centers theologically on the cross that the testimony in Paul's mind is the creed he quotes in 15:3-7.

Furthermore, in this initial opening statement (1:4-9) there are also clear pointers to both the problem addressed in the first essay and its solution. The problem is that they have divided up into parties and each thinks himself wiser than the other. Paul, somewhat ironically, starts, "You were enriched in him with all speech and all knowledge" (1:5; the irony intensifies in 4:8 with "already you are filled! Already you have become rich!"). Then in rapid sequence in these opening verses, Paul has a four-fold repetition of "our Lord

Jesus Christ.” There is no such repetition anywhere else in all of the Pauline corpus. The first three of these are in the introduction (v. 7-9), the fourth in the opening line of v. 10 which presents the problem of unity and the cross. The point is unmistakable. They have *one* Lord, not many, and they know *the testimony* regarding him—he was crucified and risen. Indeed, this testimony was confirmed among them! So why are they divided?

After this general introduction/recall of tradition Paul presents the problem dealt with in this essay—the crisis of leadership and the disunity growing out of it. The negatives are set out openly. He has been told of their divisions. He rebukes them sharply for them. Then, starting with 1:17 and continuing through 2:2, Paul presents a very carefully worded hymn on the wisdom and foolishness of God in the cross. Our analysis of this hymn is available and the details of its rhetorical form need not be repeated.⁸ However one point is worth expanding in passing. Three reasons surface in the rhetorical form that lead one to presume that Paul is using a “set piece” that he has composed previously. First, the precise nature of the rhetorical form makes clear some “midrashim” that interrupt the flow of the matching lines and appear as additions to an earlier work. Second, the form itself is chiasitic in nature with the theme of “I/we preach the cross” appearing (as is usual in such forms) at the beginning (1:17), in the middle (1:23) and at the end (2:2). In order to make a transition between the discussion of the problem of unity and its solution in Christ crucified Paul incorporates the theme of baptism into the opening line of the hymn (v. 17). The alien nature of this reference is clear when the parallelisms of the rhetorical form are observed.⁹ Then finally, the climax of the rhetorical form (as usual) occurs in the center.¹⁰ Only in this case the climax is stated with the use of two couplets that exhibit end-rhyme and a precise seven syllable count for each line. This particular poetic meter was the favorite artistic device of St. Ephraim the Syrian, writing in *Syriac*. But here we find this *Syriac* meter in *Greek*. This is surely an extremely rare phenomenon! Indeed, in describing the Greek version of Ephraim’s hymns Gwynn writes,

⁸ K. E. Bailey, “Recovering the Poetic Structure of I Cor. i 17-ii 2,” *Novum Testamentum*, Vol. XVII (1976), 265-296.

⁹ *Ibid.*, 268-269.

¹⁰ K. E. Bailey, *Poet and Peasant* (Grand Rapids: Wm. Eerdmans, 1976), p. 50f.

though faithfully reproducing his thoughts and literary method, (it) makes no attempt to retain his metrical system; but is a rendering into what in form is prose of an original which is in verse. That this should be so is unavoidable for Syriac meters are incapable of adaption to the Greek language.¹¹

This is generally true. But when the subject was important enough, amazingly Paul seems to have managed, for here in 1:23 we have just that—a *semitic* poetic meter appearing in a *Greek* text. The lines are as follows:

hē-meis de kērus-so-men	We preach
Chris-ton e-stau-rō-men-on	Christ crucified
Iou-dai-ois men skan-da-lon	to the Jews, a stumbling block
eth-ne-sin de mō-ri-an	to the gentiles, stupidity

(We have thus far observed five such couplets in Paul's writings and each is a brief creedal formulation. This semitic/Greek style may evidence composition during the early period of Paul's ministry in the region of Greek/Syriac speaking Antioch.) These three reasons make it possible to suggest that this hymn is a part of "my ways in Christ as I teach them in every church" (I Cor. 4:17).

The reworked hymn is then placed side by side with a balancing section that introduces a "hidden wisdom of God." This second section on wisdom also looks like a general statement that can easily apply to other problems and other churches and may not be merely an occasional response to a particular problem in Corinth.

After the two complementary and, at the same time, paradoxical statements on "the wisdom of the cross," Paul returns to the question of Paul, Apollos and Cephas (I,A'), only this time the reference is positive. In this section he asks, "What then is Apollos? What then is Paul? Servants through whom you believed" (3:5); and again, "This is how you *should* regard us, as servants of Christ and stewards of the mysteries of God" (4:1). He has just discussed these same mysteries (I,B,B') and here affirms that the apostles *do have* a leadership role as teachers of these mysteries and as examples in practical life. Indeed, he concludes, "I urge you, then, be imitators of me." Thus, in this first essay, all five aspects of Paul's method can be observed. As noted above these are:

The Tradition

The specific problem (presented primarily negatively)

¹¹ John Gwynn, "Ephraim Syrus: VII; His Writings, Their Characteristics," in *The Nicene and Post Nicene Fathers* (Second Series; New York: The Christian Literature Company, 1898), Vol. XII, 148.

The theological universals
 The specific problem (presented primarily positively)
 A Concluding Appeal

Seen in this fashion, in this essay Paul is not *primarily* defending his position as an apostle. Rather his focus is:

(A) You see leaders as focal points for divisions but you should see them (A') as stewards of the mysteries of God who yet *do* have a leadership role in faith and practice.

We grant that in the process Paul defends his apostleship. But his theological method (as seen here) indicates that the primary topic is the proper attitude for Christians in regard to their leaders. This brings us to the second essay.

The second essay begins with precisely the same introductory phrases that are found in the opening lines of essays IV (11:2) and V (15:1-8). That is, first appears a call to *remembrance* and then a reference to the *tradition*. Modern commentators have generally assumed that 4:17-21 is a conclusion to what precedes and that the new topic begins with chapter five and the case of incest. Our view is that 4:17 begins the new essay and that the phrase, "For this reason I sent you" (4:17), looks forwards and not backwards. The question is critical for our argument and will need to be examined with care. A number of points can be made. First is the fact that the two verses (when read together) give the reader two "therefores" in a row. This is as follows:

- (16) I urge you, *therefore* (*oun*), be imitators of me.
- (17) *Therefore* (*dia touto*), I sent to you Timothy, to remind you of my ways in Christ as I teach them everywhere in every church.

It is difficult to argue that Paul is summarizing his previous argument twice in a row with two "therefores" one after another. Rather, the first "therefore" (*oun*) is a word Paul often uses to summarize a previous discussion (cf. 10:31; 11:20; 14:23; 14:26; 15:11; 16:11; 16:18). This leaves the second phrase (*dia touto*) as an introduction to what follows. Second, the phrase "to remind you" (v. 17) is clearly the opening phrase for a new discussion in two of the following essays (11:2; 15:1). So why not here? Third, what Paul "teaches everywhere in every church" is the church tradition. Such a reference opens *each* of the five essays. This has been universally recognized in essays three, four and five. So why should a reference to these traditions be left here as a conclusion? Fourth, to our knowledge no ancient paragraph system divided the text at 5:1.

However, there is wide spread early evidence for a break at 4:16 or 17. Codex Vaticanus made a break at 4:16b (adding the admonition to imitate Paul to the new paragraph). The ancient paragraph divisions of the Northern Coptic tradition and those of the classical Armenian tradition do the same.¹² The ancient liturgy of St. James, followed by the Syrian Orthodox Church, and also the liturgy of the Greek Melkite Church of the Middle East read 4:17-5:5 as a single passage.¹³ Also, the earliest dated Arabic translation of the Pauline corpus, Sinai 151 (A.D. 867), has the first major division of I Corinthians precisely between 4:16 and 17.¹⁴ This latter MS (soon to be published by CSCO) is a work of significant scholarship in the Syriac/Arabic tradition. Thus, there is an ancient, wide-spread, serious Middle East interpretive tradition that saw 4:17-21 as a part of the opening verses in chapter five. Fifth, in the verse itself Paul discusses Timothy's impending visit and his own. Then in 5:3 this topic indirectly reappears in reference to the judgment of the immoral man. That is, Paul seems to be saying,

Some think I am not coming (4:18) but I am *indeed* coming (4:19); as a matter of fact, although I am absent in body consider me already present in spirit (5:3).

Thus the concluding verses of chapter 4 anticipate the new topic more than they look backwards to the old one. Sixth, in 4:18 Paul refers to some who are "arrogant." In 5:2 he becomes more pointed with the remark, "and you are arrogant!" Seventh, in 4:20 Paul has one of his rare occurrences of the synoptic phrase, "the kingdom of God." This phrase occurs only nine times in Paul. Six of the nine are specific references to people *not* entering the kingdom of God. Setting aside the verse under discussion, four out of these five negative references (I Cor. 6:9,10; Gal. 5:21; Eph. 5:5) specifically mention sexual immorality as one of the reasons for denial of entry into the kingdom. Thus the overwhelming weight of evidence is that when Paul is talking about sin and the kingdom of God he is

¹² G. Horner, *The Coptic Version of the New Testament in the Northern Dialect* (Osnabruck: Otto Zeller, c. 1898, 1905, 1969), Vol. III, 138-139. For the classical Armenian we have examined Codex #212 of the Armenian Patriarchal Library, Antelias, Lebanon (dated 1293), folio 220^r.

¹³ Philoxenus Jusif, Metropolitan of Mardin, *Muqaddes Ayryllirin Fihriste* (Turkish and Syriac) (Mardin: Hikmet Basimevi, 1954), p. 87; *Kitāb al Risā'il* (Arabic) (Schweir: Monastery of St. John, 1813), p. 167.

¹⁴ Harvey Staal, Editor and translator, *Codex Sinai Arabic 151: Pauline Epistles, Part II* in *Studies and Documents of the University of Utah* (Salt Lake City: University of Utah Press, 1969), Vol. XV, 121.

thinking of lists of sins that include sexual immorality. This becomes all the more evident when in this same passage in 6:9, 10 this specific connection is made. Eighth, an examination of Paul's use of *dia touto* leads one to conclude that this phrase always looks forward *in some sense*. Often it introduces a distinctively new thought with little or no reference to what has come before (cf. Rom. 15:9; I Cor. 11:30; II Cor. 4:1; 12:10; Eph. 1:15; Col. 1:9; II Thess. 2:11). Then, at other times the phrase builds on a previous discussion and moves on to introduce a new idea (cf. Rom. 1:26; 4:16; 5:12; 13:6; I Cor. 11:10; II Cor. 4:1; 7:13; Eph. 5:17; 6:13; I Thess. 3:5,7). In most of the above cases modern editors (such as RSV) have *dia touto* introduce a new paragraph. Schultz argues that in I Cor. 4:17 *dia touto* points forward.¹⁵ Conzelmann admits "this is correct; but there remains the context, 'become my imitators!' and 'Let yourselves be reminded of my ways!'"¹⁶ That is, Schultz feels the phrase looks exclusively forward. Conzelmann admits the forward thrust and affirms along with this a relationship to what precedes. Both scholars are in harmony with what we are trying to say. Yet the forward thrust seems to be the primary emphasis. We suggest a translation of

For this reason I sent to you Timothy,
my beloved and faithful child in the Lord,
to remind you of my ways in Christ
as I teach them everywhere in every church.

The reason for Timothy's visit is to remind them of Paul's ways.

Finally, there is a shift of tone between 4:14 and 4:18-21. In 4:14 Paul speaks very gently. He wants only to admonish his beloved children and not to make them ashamed. But in 4:18-21 he is threatening the *arrogant* with a *rod*!! Barrett has noted this dramatic shift of tone and writes,

At verse 14 Paul began to moderate his tone towards his readers; he did not wish to humiliate them, only to see that they were soundly instructed in Christian principles. When however he recalls the actual ... state of the Corinthian church he feels obliged to end his paragraph on a firmer note.¹⁷

The move from a gentle admonition to threats with a rod can hardly be described as merely "a firmer note." Furthermore, if

¹⁵ Anselm Schultz, *Nachfolgen und Nachahmen*, SANT, 6 (Munich: Lösel, 1962), p. 309f. (as noted in Conzelmann, *op. cit.*, p. 92, n. 15 and n. 20).

¹⁶ Conzelmann, *op. cit.*, 92, n. 20.

¹⁷ Barrett, *op. cit.*, 117.

4:14-21 is indeed one paragraph, what is there in these verses that triggers Paul's sudden anger? The text tells us that Paul (after the gentle admonition) is thinking of the universal message that he teaches everywhere in every church (v. 17). Then there is a sudden change of subject and of tone with the beginning of v. 18 where he announces, "Some are arrogant!" This dramatic shift of tone and subject we are convinced is the opening volley of the statement of the ethical problem of the second essay.

Why then, we naturally ask, have commentators and editors placed the break in subject matter at 5:1 for so long? The answer is perhaps two-fold. In 4:18-21 Paul is talking about his coming visit. Chapter five discusses incest. They seem unrelated. But in our view this coming visit is indirectly referred to in 5:3 as noted above, and thus the coming visit is an introduction to and threat for the case of incest. His point is,

I am coming, and you had better get this matter taken care of, or on my arrival there I will have to use a rod!! (4:18-21). Don't await my arrival, but consider me already present in spirit and proceed (5:3-5).

But if the dramatic new start at 4:18 is overlooked it is understandable that many have seen 5:1 as a new beginning. Furthermore, 5:1 is a startling announcement of a new topic. It descends on the consciousness of the reader (indeed) like the blow of a rod on the head! Paul says he is angry in 4:17-21, but we do not yet know why. It is our view that with exquisite skill Paul allows for an ever-so-brief semantic pause between the mention of the rod and the bringing of it down on the heads of his readers. Or to put it another way, how can an apostle effectively introduce such a difficult and potentially explosive topic *in writing* in a theological essay? Paul decides on a "bull at a gate" approach and 4:18-21 is an introduction. "I am coming!" he writes, "and the arrogant had better step aside (4:18-21)! Consider me already present and deal with this (5:1-5)!" Thus again, 4:18 appears as a dramatic introduction to a new topic and 5:1 is best understood as a continuation of that same theme.

In conclusion we can say that there are numerous and significant arguments for seeing 4:18-21 as an introduction to the topic of immorality and not a dangling personal aside. Thus the second essay opens like each of the other four with a reference to *the traditions*. Like two of them it prefaces this reference with a call to remember.

What then of the essay itself? This second essay is a precise example of Paul's theological method as seen above. Summarized it is as follows:

1. The Call to Remembrance
Reference to the Tradition
2. An introduction of the negative aspects of the problem—incest, homosexuality, immorality and the necessary judgment (5:1-6:11a)
3. Two complementary theological themes that provide a foundation for addressing the problem: food and sex are not equal + the cross, the resurrection, the trinity and sexuality (6:11b-20).
4. A presentation of positive patterns of Christian sexuality (7)
5. A Concluding Appeal (7:40b)

In a previous study we have presented a detailed analysis of the central theological affirmations of this second essay.¹⁸ We can only observe in passing that the language used here also exhibits extreme care and precision. If anywhere, in this text we are dealing with "what Paul teaches everywhere in every church" (4:17). We would suggest that, like the case of "no wisdom/wisdom" (the center of the first essay), here also Paul takes the occasion of the problem of incest in Corinth to present some previously prepared material that he now reshapes into a new whole and here applies to the Corinthian problem. The pattern of ethics - theology - ethics is unmistakable.

Paul's concluding appeal to this essay (7:40b) is less emphasized. The concluding appeals at the ends of each of the other four seem more pointed. This is probably because his appeal in this case is diffused all through the second ethical section (ch 7). That is, each case presented has some form of a personal appeal (cf. v. 7, 8, 10, 12, 24, 25). Thus the final appeal (v. 40b) has no summarizing "therefore brethren." The theme, "Be imitators of me," does not fit.

What then of the famous reference to the Corinthians' written questions in 7:1 that appears in the middle of this essay (as we have outlined it)? Traditionally 7:1 is seen as the crucial turning point of the outline of the entire book, as we have noted. Many, such as Barrett, structure their outline of the whole book around this

¹⁸ K. Bailey, "Paul's Theological Foundation for Human Sexuality: I Cor. 6:9-20 in the Light of Rhetorical Criticism," *Theological Review* (of the Near East School of Theology), Vol. III/1 (April, 1980), 27-41.

verse.¹⁹ This view we feel fails to take sufficient note of 11:34b which reads, "About the other things I will give directions when I come." The traditional explanation of this verse is that Paul refers here only to other aspects of the Lord's Supper. But is it not possible to assume that he has selected from their letter the issues he feels deserve a written answer and that the rest of their written and oral questions he sets aside? Paul made his selection and then constructed *his own* essays. Chapters 12-16 may be issues that they have not raised at all. Rather Paul has solicited information from his Corinthian visitors, read the letter sent to him and decided himself what issues needed immediate attention in writing. Again, *Paul* sets the outline, not the Corinthians.

We would suggest two alternate ways to understand 7:1. First, it is possible that when Paul refers to "the things about which you wrote," he means that they wrote asking about marriage, remarriage, marriage to non-believers and the like. They did *not* write about incest, visiting prostitutes and homosexuality. He deals first with the sexual questions that they did *not* write about, and then in 7:1 turns to deal with the sexual questions about which they did write. That is, 7:1 may refer only to essay II. But 11:34b makes this view doubtful. More likely they have asked about many things. Paul chose to answer three of their questions in writing. These were:

1. Sexual matters (7)
2. Food offered to idols (8-10)
3. What to do about problems at the Lord's Table (11)

Thus at the end of his discussion of these questions Paul simply tells them that he will handle the other matters when he comes (11:34b). We perhaps have a similar situation in I Thess. 5:1 where Paul writes, "You have no need to have anything written to you." Thus the letter received from Corinth can be understood to have had only a minor role to play in the composition of I Corinthians rather than a major one.

This brings us to a consideration of the third essay, which deals with how a Christian is to live and witness in a pagan world. Their question (it seems) was simply, "Do we eat meat offered to idols or not?" Paul, using the same method seen above, expands their question into a full discussion of the Christian and the pagan. To see this we turn first to his outline, which is as follows:

¹⁹ Barrett, *op. cit.*, 28-29.

1. *The Creed* (one God, one Lord) is set forth along with
2. a presentation of *the problem of food offered to idols*. 8
 3. A full discussion of his freedom from/and his enslavement to all men—in order to be a *partner* with the Gospel (identification). 9
A careful theological statement on the sacraments and *partnership* with idols (non-identification). 10:1-22
4. A second discussion of *food offered to idols* with the above theological points in mind. 10:23-33
5. A Concluding Appeal. 11:1

The opening of this essay relates in style to the opening of the fourth essay. Rather than refer to the tradition and then turn to open the ethical issue to be dealt with Paul presents the problem *and along with it* recites the relevant part of the creed. The reason for this is obvious. In this case he feels he must *quote* the tradition/creed and the part he quotes relates specifically to the problem. Thus he presents them together (cf. also 10:17-32 discussed below).

The first discussion of the problem has negative references to those who think that they have “knowledge,” who are “puffed up” and have no love. They think that the question is a simple matter because “an idol has no real existence” (8). The second discussion seems to have a muted emphasis on the negative and a corresponding emphasis on positives (10:23-11:1). However, this aspect of this essay is distinctively fainter than what we observed in the first and second essays.

The theological section of this essay again presents two aspects of a single theme. The theme is identification in theology of mission. The two aspects are to identify or not to identify. He makes a case for identification first. He introduces this with a full discussion of his own personal freedom. 9:1 starts, “Am I not free?” and then in 9:19 he continues, “For though I am free from all men....” Many have assumed that here Paul (for unknown reasons) is returning to a defense of his apostleship. But, when Paul’s overall structure and his theological method is perceived, this apparent return to the question of defense of his apostleship (already dealt with in chapters three and four) becomes meaningful. Here, in chapter nine, the concern is as follows. He has (it seems) been criticized for eating meat offered to idols. His answer is:

I do not accept this criticism! First of all, I am an apostle and my position in the church is known. Second, I am *not* your employee! I support myself (although I could claim remuneration). I am a free man—but I limit my freedom in order to be a partner of the Gospel.

In the first essay (ch. 3,4) he is not trying directly to defend his apostleship but rather to give the Corinthians a non-devisive understanding of how to relate to their leaders. So here, in essay III (ch. 9), he is using the question of food offered to idols to raise the larger question of theology of mission.

After asserting his right to freedom Paul then makes a very carefully worded statement on the servanthood of identification.

The rhetorical structure of this statement is as follows:

PLATE B

I Corinthians 9:19-23

- | | | |
|----|---|---------------------|
| 1 | Free being from <i>all</i>
<i>I have made myself a slave to all</i>
<i>in order that the more I might win.</i> | All |
| 2 | I became to the Jews
like a Jew
in order that Jews I might win; | Jew |
| 3 | To those under the law
as under the law
though not being myself under the law
in order that those under the law I might win; | Jew
(Law) |
| 3' | To those outside the law
as one outside the law
not being without the law towards God
(but in the law of Christ)
in order that I might win those outside the law. | Gentile
(No law) |
| 2' | I became to weak
as one weak
in order that the weak I might win. | Gentile |
| 1' | To <i>all people</i>
<i>I have become all things</i>
<i>in order that by all means I save some.</i> | All |

All this I do on account of the Gospel
in order that a *partner of it I may become.*

(With a key word standing to the right we have tried to summarize the subjects of the various stanzas.) We observe ten pairs of lines. Each of these twenty lines has its balancing opposite. One half are on the Greeks, and one half on the Jews. There is only one dangling extra which is “but in the law of Christ.” Again, Paul may be using old and familiar material. He has specifically told them in 4:17 that he wants to recall for them what is taught in every church. This essay is discussing Christian *and pagan*. Yet these twenty lines are on how the Christian must relate to pagans *and Jews*. The ten lines on the Jews are unnecessary. But, how could he leave out the ten opening lines of a set of ten parallelisms? Surely this marvelous statement is one of those universals that he teaches everywhere and is re-using here, even though one-half of it is outside the topic of the essay.

Significantly, Paul does *not* say that for the Greeks he becomes a Greek, nor that for the gentiles he becomes a gentile. That is impossible. He is a Jew. Identification has its limits. He is honest with himself and his readers. Only one who has spent decades living in a culture radically different from his own can appreciate the fine touch here evidenced. Paul’s climax in this case is at the end with the phrase,

All this I do on account of the Gospel
in order that a *partner* (*sug-koinōnos*) of it I may become.

He does not say that he identifies in order that *the Gospel* may go forward, but rather that *he may go with the Gospel*. The Gospel is already at work as a living force in both cultures. The word has become flesh in the Greek as well as the Jewish world. If he fails to follow it *he* will be left behind.

After this strong appeal for identification Paul then presents the other side of the coin with a call for non-identification in a discussion of sacraments and ethics (10:1-22). The heart of this second discussion also appears at the end of the section (10:14-22). It likewise follows a carefully constructed rhetorical form which is shown in Plate C below.

It is beyond the scope of this essay to exegete the theological sections of this third essay. We can only make a few observations in passing. First, regarding the rhetoric of the two passages, we note that each presents precisely ten matched pairs of lines. Each has one “midrash” like a footnote that appears in the midst of the ten

PLATE C

I Corinthians 10:14-22

THEREFORE, MY BELOVED, FLEE FROM THE WORSHIP OF IDOLS

I speak as to sensible people;
judge for yourselves what I say.

Opening

- 1 The *cup of blessing* which we bless,
is it not a *partnership* in the blood of Christ?

Cup

The *bread* which we break,
is it not a *partnership* in the body of Christ?
(Because there is one loaf
we who are many are one body,
for we all *partake* of the same loaf.)

Bread

- Look at Israel according to the flesh,
2 are not those who eat the sacrifices
partners in the altar?

Partners

What do I say then?

- 3 That food *sacrificed to idols* is anything?
Or that an *idol* is anything?

Sacrifice
to idols

- 3' No, but what the pagans *sacrifice is to demons*,
not to God do they sacrifice.

Sacrifice
to demons

- 2' I do not want you to be
partners with demons.

Partners

- 1' You cannot *drink the cup of the Lord*
and the cup of demons.

Cup

You cannot *partake* of the *table of the Lord*
and the table of demons.

Bread

Shall we provoke the Lord to jealousy?
Are we stronger than He?

Closing

parallelisms. Thus, in each case we are perhaps dealing with theological universals that Paul teaches everywhere. The theological paradox of identification versus non-identification is brilliantly stated. The key concept of "participation" appears central to each side of the coin. The Christian is to participate with Jews and Greeks in order to become a *partner* of the Gospel. But there is a line that cannot be crossed. Syncretism is not advocated. There is to be no *partnership* with demons. After this dialogical

theological section Paul returns to the ethical question of food offered to idols. His closing appeal is an expansion of the call we observed at the end of his first essay in 4:16. This brings us to Paul's fourth essay.

We have noted again and again that Paul works with matching pairs of ideas. We have seen this on the level of individual lines as well as on the level of matching stanzas, paragraphs and topics. Is it not also possible to see a matching of pairs when full essays are compared? Essay I and Essay V bring the cross and resurrection together naturally and unmistakably. We would suggest that Paul has also matched II and IV. In the first, relations between men and women in the human family are dealt with; in the second, men and women in worship is discussed. Or, in the first essay the theological section discusses *sex* while in the center of the second we find the topic of *love*. Thus, like sections I and V, sections II and IV can be seen to be two halves of a whole. What then are the particulars of Paul's fourth essay?

All aspects of the observed theological method are present. They are as follows:

1. The tradition: the call to remember
 - a. + The reference to the tradition, but without a quotation from it (11:2)
 - b. + A quotation of the tradition in connection with the discussion of the problem (11:23-26)
2. Two problems connected with worship are presented (11). These are:
 - a. The head coverings of men and women prophets
 - b. Drunkenness and gluttony at Holy Communion (negatives - strong)
3. The problem of spiritual gifts (12). Someone thinks that by the spirit he can say, "Jesus is cursed!" (negatives - strong)
 4. Love and the spiritual gifts: love is the one universal (13:1-3)
 Love defined positively and negatively (13:4-7)
 Love and the spiritual gifts: the greatest is love (13:8-14:1)
3. The problem of spiritual gifts (14:2-25) (negatives less strong)
2. Two problems connected with worship are presented (14:26-36). These are:
 - a. They all want to talk at once.
 - b. The women interrupt the speakers with their questions (negatives less strong)
1. A concluding appeal (14:37-40)

Each essay, while following the same theological methodology, has its own uniqueness. In this case the ethical section deals with two topics rather than one. The reason for this is obvious. Both the problem of "men and women in worship" and "spiritual gifts"

relate to worship and the theological foundation of love is required for each. Thus it is only natural for Paul to discuss them together. Significantly there are two problems discussed in each section on worship. These are as seen above:

The first section (worship)

- a. The head coverings of men and women prophets 11:2-16
- b. Drunkenness and gluttony at Holy Communion 11:17-34

The second section (worship)

- a. They all want to talk at once 14:26-33
- b. The women interrupt the speakers with their questions 14:34-36

Thus, the opening discussion of ethics in this essay deals with two related areas of concern (worship and gifts) and the first of them divides likewise into two parts. In this case how does Paul quote the tradition?

Paul's method of quoting the tradition in this essay exhibits some significant features. The tradition is referred to twice, once with the phrase "the tradition" (11:2) with no quotation, and the second time with the well known rabbinic formula for tradition quotations, "what I received I delivered to you," along with an extended quotation (11:23-26). Two questions are raised—why are there two references (one a quotation) to the tradition, and why are they introduced in different ways? The answer to the first of these questions is obvious. Paul here discusses two different problems relating to worship, as we have observed. The first is the head covering of the prophets, and second, gluttony and drunkenness at Holy Communion. In regard to the first, the Corinthians *are* observing the traditions. Thus Paul congratulates them for *remembering him* and for *maintaining the traditions*. No quotation is necessary. In the second case he specifically says that he cannot commend them (11:17) and (as in the third essay) he quotes the tradition in the middle of his discussion of the problem (11:17-34). In short, two related problems call for a double reference to the tradition. Their failures in the second necessitate a specific quotation.

What then is the significance of the different ways the tradition is quoted? From these differences, along with observations of the other tradition references, we can see that "the tradition" for Paul is composed of at least three kinds of material. These are:

1. Creeds (seen in the introductions to Essay III and V) that do (15:3) or do not (8:6) use the tradition recitation formula.
2. Material that warrants the formula, "what I received I delivered to you," that is *from the Lord*. In this connection the tradition reference in the first essay (1:6)

may be a *subjective* genitive, and may refer to Dominical materials. The word about divorce is from the Lord (7:10; cf. also 9:14 and 11:23-26).

3. Materials that warrant the title "the traditions" that do *not* use the formula "what I received I delivered" and are closely linked to Paul and what he teaches (cf. 11:2). Paul does not use the word "the traditions" in 4:17 but rather talks of "my ways in Christ, as I teach them everywhere in every church." This latter reference can be seen as falling into this third category. On the basis of 11:2 these teaching materials, taught by Paul in every church, appear to be a part of "the traditions" and Paul himself is their source.

The presence of the chapter on love in the middle of the discussion of spiritual gifts has long been noted. Some have offered reasons for chapter 13 being out of place.²⁰ But on the basis of Paul's theological method (here seen all through the book) we can affirm that this chapter is precisely where Paul wants it. Again we can easily entertain the possibility that Paul is reusing older material in this chapter on love.

In each of the previous essays the central theological section has presented two sides of a single theme. This feature is repeated here once and perhaps twice. The chapter on love opens (v. 1-3) and closes (v. 8-11) with discussions of love and the spiritual gifts. But the emphasis shifts. In the first discussion (v. 1-3) the reader is told that love is the only universal element that must be present in each of the other forms of piety, while in the second section (v. 8-11) we discover that only faith, hope and love remain, of which love is the greatest. Then, in the very center (v. 4-7), love is defined both positively and negatively.

We have argued that these essays are constructed on the pattern of ethics - theology - ethics. The question could be raised, Is not the central section of this essay an *ethical* discussion, and thus, in this fourth essay, do we not have ethics - ethics - ethics? However, every ethical discussion involves theology and all theology involves ethics. Here the pattern of problem - solution - problem, or, particular - universal - particular, is perhaps more useful as a framework within which to view the material. Yet, at the same time, chapter 13

²⁰ Cf. W. Schmithals, *Gnosticism in Corinth* (Nashville: Abingdon Press, 1971), p. 95. Schmithals's suggestion is a transposition of chapters 13 and 14. This brings the two discussions of gifts together with the chapter on love at the end. Although they reject the shift of materials, in a discussion of this suggestion Orr/Walther note that such a move would "improve the logic of the discussion. 12:31b would follow 14:40, and ch. 13 would be the climax of the whole section." *Op. cit.*, 290. Our question is, Whose logic will be improved by such a shift? Aristotle's or Jeremiah's? It is our view that chapter 13 is *already* placed in the climax of the section which is *in the middle*!

is theological. Faith, hope and love appear three times (once in each section) when the stronger text, "that I may boast," is restored to verse three, and the discussion concludes in verses 8-13 on eschatology. For Paul, theology and ethics are always inseparable. This can clearly be seen in this chapter. Thus Paul's theological method is maintained in this fourth essay.

A comparison between the opening and closing ethical sections again reveals strong negatives in the opening sections. In his first presentation of problems of worship (11) Paul mentions their drunkenness at communion. In the second discussion of worship (14:26-36) there *are* negatives (the brethren all want to talk at once, and the women interrupt the speakers with questions). But these negatives are much milder than the drunkenness at the Table discussed earlier. In the two sections on gifts we can see the same phenomenon. In the opening section (12) someone is saying, "Jesus is cursed." In the second discussion of the same topic there is only a gentle appeal to prefer prophecy over tongues. Thus the previously noticed negative emphasis in the opening paragraphs on ethics is clearly repeated in this essay. Finally, like the resolution of a piece of music, Paul turns to his concluding essay.

The fifth essay (on the resurrection) complements the first (on the cross) as we have noted. Paul's outline for the essay is as follows:

The *call to remembrance* (v. 1-2)

The *tradition/creed* (v. 3-11)

A The *presentation of the theological problem*—some say Christ is not raised. Paul answers with great precision of language—Christ *is* raised.

B *Adam and Christ* are discussed in the context of setting forth God's final plan for all things (v. 21-28).

C Parables and illustrations that relate personally both to their lives and his are placed in the center between two discussions of Adam and Christ (v. 29-34).

B' *Adam and Christ* are again discussed but now with a new topic—that of the nature of the spiritual body (v. 35-50).

A' The *great mystery of the resurrection* that overcomes death, sin and the law conclude the theological presentation (v. 51-57).

The concluding appeal (v. 58)

This essay has a more obvious call to *remember* and a presentation of a long quote from the tradition/creed. We have already noted some parallels between the opening of this essay and the introduction to the first essay. More fully seen these are as follows:

1:4-9

The grace of God which was given
to you

The testimony of Christ

was confirmed among you

you wait for the revealing of
our Lord Jesus Christ,
who will sustain you to the end.

15:1-7

The gospel, which you received

I delivered to you—what I received—
Christ died for our sins—

He was raised on the third day

(the Gospel) in which you stand
by which you are saved

if you hold it fast
unless you believed in vain.

This strong linkage between the first and the fifth essays can be seen through other parts of the final essay to which we now turn.

In each essay we have noted some variety of presentation. The fifth essay also demonstrates its own uniqueness. In the second section of this essay we find a shift in the structure. In each of the first four essays Paul's second section discussed an *ethical* problem that had *theological* implications. Thus his outline was ethics—*theology*—ethics. But in this case the problem is *theological*; some in Corinth deny the resurrection. Thus Paul still presents the problem of the essay immediately after a presentation of a quotation from the tradition, but because it is a *theological* rather than an *ethical* problem the outline of this essay is *theology*—ethics—*theology*. We have noted that Paul presents the theological universals of each essay with great precision of language. The same can be seen here. The rhetorical form of the opening section of this fifth essay is shown in Plate D below.

Again Paul is working with ten pairs of lines (with one or perhaps two unmatched extras). The positive affirmation of "Christ is raised" occurs at the beginning, the middle and at the end. The rest of the matching lines are all negatives. In units 3 and 3' the matching pairs are particularly precise. Then, comparisons with the opening theological statement of the first essay (on the cross) are revealing. In that statement (1:17-2:2) we can observe the identical phenomenon of a presentation of "the message" at the beginning (v.17), the middle (v. 1:23) and the end (2:2), only in that first essay the *message* was "we preach Christ crucified" and now it is "we preach Christ raised." In each presentation the *denials* of the preaching appear also in the same place. That is, in 1:17-2:2 we have:

PLATE D

I Corinthians 15:12-20

- | | | | |
|------|--|--|--------------------------|
| 1 | And if Christ is preached
as "RAISED FROM THE DEAD" | Christ is raised | (+) |
| 2 | How can some of you say,
"There is <i>no resurrection</i> of the dead?" | Your view:
No resurrection | (-) |
| 3 a | And if there is no resurrection of the dead | No ressur. | (-) |
| b | then Christ has not been raised, | No faith | |
| c | and if Christ has not been raised | | |
| d | then <i>our preaching</i> is <i>empty</i> , and your faith is empty. | | |
| 4 | We are even found to be <i>misrepresenting God</i>
because we witness of God,
"He raised the Messiah,"
whom he did not raise
(if it is true that the <i>dead are not raised</i>). | Not raised
Our witness
Christ raised
Not raised | (-)
(+)
(+)
(-) |
| 3' a | For if <i>the dead are not raised</i> | No ressur. | (-) |
| b | then Christ has not been raised, | No faith | |
| c | and if Christ has not been raised | | |
| d | your faith is futile and <i>you</i> are still <i>in your sins</i> . | | |
| 2' | Then also <i>those asleep</i> in Christ <i>have perished</i> .
If in this life in Christ we have hope only
we are of all men most to be pitied. | Results of
your view | (-) |
| 1' | But now CHRIST HAS BEEN RAISED from the dead,
the first fruits of those asleep. | Christ is raised | (+) |

We preach Christ crucified (1:17)

Jews and Greeks find this ridiculous

Believers see it as the power and wisdom of God (1:18-22)

We preach Christ crucified (1:23)

Jews and Greeks find this ridiculous

Believers see it as power and wisdom (1:23b-31)

We preach Christ crucified (2:1-2)

Then in 15:12-20 the rhetorical form in summary is:

We preach Christ risen (v. 12)

If the dead are not raised - then - (13-14)

We witness of God, "He raised the Messiah" (15)

If the dead are not raised - then - (16-19)

Now *Christ has been raised* (v. 20)

Furthermore, we noticed above that Paul managed to affirm "we preach Christ crucified" in Greek using a semitic poetical meter. This remarkable phenomenon may be evidenced here as well. The opening line of this affirmation reads:

Khris-tos de key-rus-se-tai
ek nek-ron e-gey-ger-tai

Christ is preached
raised from the dead

This same meter is used in Philippians 2:11, again in a creedal affirmation. Here the meter is less perfect in that we have omitted the *hoti* from the text and moved the connective *de* as a result. Our assumption is that these creedal formulations may have been chanted in worship, and that in such a context the *hoti* would have been omitted. Middle Easterners have enormous linguistic skills at composing such seven syllable couplets for almost any occasion and we are not surprised to find them, only startled to discover them in *Greek*. Returning then to the fifth essay in I Corinthians, these parallels between the opening theological section of the first and the last essays make even more certain that Paul is deliberately presenting two aspects of a theological whole.

In his second paragraph, as we have indicated, he discusses *Adam and Christ*. In the center he points out the *ethical implications* of resurrection for them as well as for himself. After returning to a different aspect of his *Adam and Christ* theology, he concludes with a theological affirmation that has a prophetic precision of which Jeremiah would have been proud. Again Paul uses almost exactly twenty lines. Its non-inverted rhetorical form is given in Plate E below.

In the fourth essay Paul presented *two related ethical problems* (worship irregularities + spiritual gifts) and in the middle of them reflected on a *single theological affirmation* (love). In this final essay he reverses the process. Here we have *two related theological topics* (resurrection + Adam and Christ) and in the center of them there is a single paragraph on related *ethical implications*.

In the second theological section of the first essay (I, Bξ) Paul told them that *the cross* was a “secret, hidden *mystery of God*,” of which the apostles were stewards. Now, in the closing theological section of the last essay we find the apostle *revealing a mystery related to the resurrection*. When one senses the precise nature of the resolution of these central themes the reader experiences an aesthetic and intellectual sense of completion like that which comes after the ceasing of exquisite music.

Turning from the overall structure of the essays, a glance at the smaller units exhibits a significant comparison. Thus far in the larger essays we have seen four cases of

PLATE E

I Corinthians 15:51-57

Lo! I tell you a mystery.

We shall not all sleep,
but we shall all be changed
 in a moment,
 in the twinkling of an eye,
 at the last trumpet.

For the trumpet will sound
and the dead will be raised imperishable,
and we shall be changed.

For this perishable nature must put on the imperishable
and this mortal nature must put on immortality.

When the perishable puts on the imperishable,
and the mortal puts on immortality,
then shall come to pass the saying that is written:
 “Death is swallowed up in victory.
 O death, where is thy victory?
 O death, where is thy sting?”

The sting of death is sin,
and the power of sin is the law;
but thanks be to God
who gives us the victory
through our Lord Jesus Christ.

ethics + theology + ethics
and one case of

theology + ethics + theology

In addition to this overall theological method there is a similar division observable within some of the smaller paragraphs of Paul's presentation. For purposes of illustration we would briefly present five.

In chapter three we find:

Paul, and Apollos (3:1-4)
 the *parable* of the field (3:5-9)
 the *parable* of the building (3:9-15)
Paul, Apollos and Cephas (3:18-23)

In the discussion of incest we observe:

The Kingdom of God and the case of incest (4:18-5:13)
 Judge yourselves, don't go to the law (6:1-8)
Heterosexual and homosexual sinners will not inherit the kingdom (6:9-10)

In the discussion of Christian patterns of sexuality we read:

Patterns of Christian sexuality (7:1-16)
 Stay as you were called (7:17-24)
 Patterns for Christian sexuality (7:25-40)

The first discussion of spiritual gifts divides as follows:

A variety of gifts (12:1-11)
 the *parable* of the body (12:12-26)
 A variety of gifts (12:27-31)

The second discussion of gifts presents:

Prophecy is better than tongues (14:1b-5)
 the *parable* of the flute (v. 7)
 the *parable* of the bugle (v. 8-9)
 the *parable* of the foreign language (v. 11, 12)
 Prophecy is better than tongues (14:13-25)

In his discussion of sacraments and ethics Paul writes:

Sacraments (Moses and the sacramental food and drink) (10:1-5)
 Ethics (10:6-13)
 Sacraments (The Lord's table and the table of idols) (10:14-22)

Of special interest is the fact that parables are embedded in the centers of larger discussions. We have found clear cases of this in Luke's gospel in both the parable of the Two Debtors and in the parable of the Camel and the Needle's Eye.²¹ But behind Luke is Isaiah 55:8-9 which reads,

For *my thoughts* are not *your thoughts*,
 neither are *your ways my ways*, says the Lord;
 for as the heavens are higher than the earth
 so are *my ways* higher than *your ways*,
 and *my thoughts* than *your thoughts*.

This brief passage can be summarized as follows:

My thoughts/ways and your thoughts/ways
a parable
 My thoughts/ways and your thoughts/ways

Trained rabbis were expected to memorize the tradition which included the "scriptures," and meant for Paul at least the law, the prophets and the Psalms. It is not surprising therefore to find the Christian rabbi using rhetorical forms and styles that must surely have been a part of his blood stream after the rigorous memoriza-

²¹ K. E. Bailey, *Through Peasant Eyes* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1981), p. 2f., 158f.

tion requirements of the rabbinic schools. It is from this source that we must surely expect Paul's method and style to have evolved.²²

This brings us back to a second look at 4:17, where Paul tells his readers that Timothy has been sent to them to remind them of Paul's *ways* in Christ as he teaches them everywhere in every church. How, we ask, does Paul teach his "ways in Christ" in every church? Is it not possible to see I Corinthians as a five-fold answer to this question? His way/ method is to quote the tradition, present an ethical problem, discuss the theological basis necessary for an answer, and then return to the problem in a new light. Timothy is not the bearer of this letter (cf. 16:10) and thus 4:17 is not an epistolary aorist. Yet, is it not possible to see in Paul's affirmation of the mandate for Timothy's mission an indication of Paul's own theological method as well?

We conclude that what we have seen thus far has significance for our understanding of Paul as well as an understanding of I Corinthians. When Paul is talking about his own vision of his own identity and destiny he writes,

He who *set me apart before I was born,*
and *called me* through his grace
was pleased to reveal his Son to/in me
in order that I might preach him *among the nations.*

The parallels with Jeremiah's call are obvious (Jer. 1:4). Thus, in some very deep sense, Paul sees himself as a new Jeremiah. Is I Corinthians an "occasional book?" Yes, and so is the book of Jeremiah! The first Jeremiah also faced many critical problems. Yet he managed to proclaim a *written* message with great style and grandeur. Should not the new Jeremiah do the same?²³

We saw the close relationships between the opening theological sections of the first and last essays. In like manner there is a striking relationship between the closing sections of each of these same two essays. In the final section of the first essay Paul says that he is a "steward of the mysteries of God." In the final section of the last

²² For a discussion of the history of Biblical rhetorical forms, cf. Bailey, *Poet and Peasant*, *op. cit.*, 44-74.

²³ William Holladay has already demonstrated the presence in Jeremiah of a significant number of rhetorical forms similar to what we have observed in I Corinthians. Cf. "The Recovery of Poetic Passages of Jeremiah," *JBL*, vol. 85 (1966), 401-435; "Style, Irony and Authenticity in Jeremiah," *JBL*, vol. 81 (1962), 44-54; *The Architecture of Jeremiah 1-20* (Lewisburg, Pa.: Bucknell University Press, 1974).

essay he *reveals* one of those mysteries (15:51-57). That is, in 4:1 Paul asks to be seen as a

hupēretēs of Christ and
steward of the mysteries of God.

Jesus is the *r'sh hknsth*, the “head of the assembly/synagogue” and Paul is his *hazzan-hupēretēs* (assistant/keeper of the scrolls).²⁴ These two lines are in parallel and the “*hupēretēs* of Christ” is the steward of the mysteries of God. What mysteries, we ask. Does not the steward himself reveal to us one of them in the parallel paragraph in I Cor. 15:51-57?

Then, finally, is not this latter passage possibly the last of a list of theological essays/mysteries that began with the hidden mystery of the cross (1:17-2:16)? It is well known that Jewish rabbis passed on to their students blocks of formalized material. Is it not possible to see the universal theological statements that appear at the center of each of the five essays of I Corinthians as in *some* way a part of what Paul teaches in *some form* in every place? At the time of the composition of I Corinthians Paul was likely lecturing in the hall of Tyrannus (Acts 19:9). Is it not possible that in this book we have the theology of five of his lectures? Were the subjects of cross, sex, pagans, worship and resurrection *only* taught to the Corinthians?²⁵

In the light of the above, we conclude that Paul's first letter to the Corinthians is neither a mass of loosely joined paragraphs on various topics, nor a series of letters brought together by an editor, but is a masterpiece of theology and ethics with a coherent inner structure and logic that equals and even perhaps surpasses his letter to the Romans. Indeed, these two great letters can be seen as twin supporting columns of his theology. In Romans the central essay discusses Christian and Jew (Roman 9-11). The corresponding central essay of I Corinthians tells primarily of Christian and pagan (I Cor. 8-10). We are accustomed to looking at any text of Romans in the light of the overall structure of the entire epistle. We submit that the same must be done for I Corinthians. Thus, through a careful examination of Paul's theological method, it is possible to

²⁴ For a description of the administrative officers of the synagogue and their duties, cf. S. Safrai, “The Synagogue” in *The Jewish People in the First Century*, edited by S. Safrai et al (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1976), Vol. II, 908-944, especially 927-937.

²⁵ I Cor. 1:2 makes clear that all Christians are addressed.

discover more about the man and more about his intended meaning both for the Corinthians as well as for “every church everywhere.” For different reasons we can agree with what Godet said nearly a hundred years ago when he wrote, “Never ... was an intellectual edifice more admirably conceived and carried out than the First Epistle to the Corinthians.”²⁶

²⁶ F. L. Godet, *op. cit.*, 31.